from the coast, among them the Narmada, with its distinctive mountain ramparts on both banks – the so-called Vindhyan supergroup. A by-product of these Vindhyan rock formations and the Deccan ‘traps’ further inland is the presence of rock overhangs which provide perfect shelters for man and beast. From the 1860s onwards archaeologists became increasingly aware that such rock-shelters had served as rainy-season retreats for all sorts of ascetics, but Jains and Buddhists in particular. One of those archaeologists, Archibald Carllyle of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), went on to discover that many of these same rock-shelters had also housed much earlier human inhabitants, who had left paintings on the walls, ‘all evidently of great age, done in red colour … to illustrate in a very stiff and archaic manner scenes in the life of the ancient stone chippers’. Sadly for poor Carllyle, he became increasingly irrational and even violent, leading to his dismissal before he could take his discoveries further.

A few years ago, while visiting an early Buddhist monastic complex near the village of Panguraria, sited on a spur of the Vindhyas overlooking the Narmada River west of the town of Obaidullaganj, I found time to explore an extended line of rock-shelters. Some had crude bed-platforms cut into their floors by their Buddhist occupants but nearly all showed signs of much earlier human habitation in the form of simple paintings on the walls or overhangs. Often these were no more than the classic ‘hand impressions’ found in caves and rock-shelters all over the world, but others showed animals being hunted by men armed with bows and arrows. More recent paintings, using a white lime-based paint rather than the red ochre found in the earlier wall paintings, were of men mounted on horses, armed with swords and spears.

Those particular rock-shelter paintings at Panguraria had first been spotted in 1970 by a team of archaeologists from the Nagpur Circle of the ASI looking for signs of early human